

Study Questions: Learning

1. Distinguish between parameter learning and structure learning in Active Inference. Give a philosophical example of each.
2. What is Bayesian Model Reduction (BMR), and why is it philosophically significant?
3. How does the Active Inference account of learning differ from the behaviorist account (Skinner)?
4. Explain the concept of niche construction. How does it challenge the view that evolution is purely a matter of natural selection?
5. How does von Uexküll's concept of *Umwelt* relate to the Active Inference view of learning?
6. What does it mean to say that "learning changes the agent, not just the agent's beliefs"? Is this merely poetic or philosophically substantive?
7. How does the concept of *Bildung* (self-formation through education) relate to the Active Inference account of learning?
8. Explain the paradox: the agent who needs to learn is not yet the agent who has learned. How does Active Inference handle this?
9. How does Active Inference's account of learning relate to Kuhn's concept of paradigm shifts in science?
10. Can an agent resist learning? What would this look like in Active Inference terms?
11. How does Kierkegaard's concept of "the leap" relate to structure learning (adding a new model component)?
12. If learning is the updating of a generative model, what role do emotions play? Are emotions learning signals?
13. How does Active Inference account for the difference between rote memorization and deep understanding?
14. What is the "complexity" term in Bayesian model evidence, and why does it favor simpler models? Connect this to Occam's Razor.
15. How does the concept of habitual learning (automating previously deliberate behaviors) relate to precision dynamics?
16. If an agent constructs its niche, is it adapting to the environment or adapting the environment to itself? Can the two be distinguished?

17. How does sleep contribute to learning in the Active Inference framework? What is the philosophical significance of consolidation?
18. Compare the Active Inference account of learning with Piaget's concepts of assimilation and accommodation.
19. How does the concept of "epistemic foraging" (seeking information) relate to the philosophical virtue of curiosity?
20. Construct an argument: Does the Active Inference account of learning imply that personal identity is unstable? If I am my generative model and my model changes, am I still "me"?